



Domestic boost: India's Test captain Shubman Gill is set to lead North Zone in the 2025-26 Duleep Trophy, which will kick off the domestic season in Bengaluru later this month. GETTYIMAGES

Sachin Tendulkar and Jimmy Anderson, two of cricket's greatest legends. One would have expected both to be present to give the trophy to the two captains, especially since the series ended in a draw. To the best of one's knowledge, both were in England at the time. So, were they simply not invited? Or was this similar to what happened in Australia earlier this year, when only Allan Border was asked to present the Border-Gavaskar Trophy because Australia had won the series? Since this England series was drawn, perhaps neither was asked to attend the presentation. Mostly around the world, administrators are brought in to ensure profits and are quite good at it, but they may not have much knowledge about the history of the sport they are presiding over. So, these little gestures are not in their scheme of things. Nobody from the Pataudi family was there either, for the Pataudi medal, which was to be presented to the winning team's captain. The drawn series showed how silly this idea was of trying to make up to the Pataudis by retiring the trophy named after them. Every time the series is drawn, the medal can't be presented, can it? Wouldn't it be

better, therefore, to have the medal for the Man of the Series than give it to the winning team's captain? And what if the captain himself has had an ordinary series and had little impact on the result?

If there had been a result and the Pataudi medal had to be given to the Man of the Series, it would have been a tough choice, for both skippers were simply outstanding.

There will be several moments to cherish from the series: Gill's batting — very rarely do you get to see batting as pure as this — and his captaincy, Stokes' superhuman efforts with both bat and ball, the Indian fast bowlers' marathon spells, Joe Root's classy centuries, Rishabh Pant batting as only he can, as also Harry Brook, and both also chirping as only they can.

But the enduring memory will always be Mohammed Siraj's yorker that flattened the off-stump of Gus Atkinson to give India a win to level the series. After the disappointing last season in Test cricket, this would no doubt be the happiest moment in recent times for Indian cricket lovers.

Thank you, Shubman, and your boys.